



PATHWAYS TO AUTHENTIC COLLEGE EXPERIENCES

What is the PACE Program?

[Pathways to Authentic College Experiences](#) (PACE) is an inclusive college certificate program for students with intellectual or developmental disability. In 2020, Saint Joseph's University received a Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID) grant from the United States Department of Education. The PACE program will welcome its first 3 students during the fall 2022 semester. As a part of this program, students audit classes, live either on campus in residence halls or, if local, commute to campus daily, have paid work experiences on and off campus, and earn an Integrated Professional Studies certificate.

Meet the PACE Team

As a professor with a student participating in the PACE program enrolled in your class, it will be helpful for you to become acquainted with the PACE program staff. Please feel free to reach out to them at any time regarding all student and coursework-specific suggestions, questions, concerns, and/or one-on-one training and support. For general questions, the PACE team can be contacted at PACE@sju.edu.

Kaitlyn Martin is the PACE Program Director; she is responsible for overseeing the general operations of the PACE program and the collection of data for the TPSID grant. Kaitlyn is a graduate of the Special Education Department at Saint Joe's and is thrilled to support future hawks in her new role at SJU. Please contact Kaitlyn for any general questions about the PACE program; she can be reached by email at kmartin@sju.edu or by phone at 610-660-2948.

Rosemary Theveny - is the PACE Program Coordinator; she is responsible for recruiting, training, and supervising all peer academic and social coaches. Rosemary is the primary contact for any questions or concerns regarding peer coaching support; Rosemary can be reached via email at rtheveny@sju.edu.

Dr. Cheryl George is an Associate Professor and Chair of the Special Education Department; Dr. George serves as the Principal Investigator and Co-Project Director on the PACE project. Dr. George leads the PACE team in the development and implementation of the PACE program. She is also responsible for ensuring that the program complies with all requirements associated with the TPSID grant. Dr. George can be reached at cgeorge@sju.edu.

Dr. Mollie Sheppard is an Associate Professor in the Special Education Department and serves as the Co-Project Director of the PACE project. Dr. Sheppard is responsible for faculty development and will be the primary contact for any questions, concerns, or training regarding the accessibility of coursework for SJU students enrolled through PACE. Additionally, she and Dr. George will be co-chairing a Teaching and Learning Community through the SJU Office of Teaching and Learning that will meet monthly to discuss how to incorporate the principles of Universal Design for Learning (UDL) into your coursework. If you have any questions regarding your course's modified syllabus or a student's learning contract, Dr. Sheppard can be reached at msheppar@sju.edu.

Dr. Jim Johnson is a Clinical Assistant Professor in the Special Education Department and serves as the Local Education Agency (LEA) Coordinator of the PACE project. Dr. Johnson is responsible for recruiting and admitting prospective students to the program. For questions regarding the admissions process, Dr. Johnson can be reached at jjohns01@sju.edu.

Meaningful Participation

Coursework may need to be modified to ensure meaningful participation for students who are part of the PACE program (see Student Expectations). Meaningful participation is determined individually with support from the PACE Team and articulated in the [Student Learning Contract](#). These contracts will be aligned to your course learning objectives and developed by the PACE team. The PACE program does not expect professors to change their course format or materials to support an individual student; however, if you are interested, Mollie Sheppard and Cheryl George will be co-chairing a Teaching and Learning Community through the SJU Office of Teaching and Learning that will meet monthly to discuss how to incorporate the principles of Universal Design for Learning (UDL) into your coursework. Please reach out to Mollie at msheppar@sju.edu to learn more about the UDL Teaching and Learning Community of Practice.

Student Learning Contracts

Most students participating in the PACE program audit their courses, which count toward completion of a non-degree certificate from Saint Joseph's University*. To assist you with determining how to determine if the student in your class has participated meaningfully, each student will have a [Student Learning Contract](#) that clearly outlines what successful engagement in a course looks like. [Student Learning Contracts](#) are tailored to each student.

There will be a second measure called an [Academic Progress Rubric](#) that addresses the following areas:

- Satisfactory Attendance
- Appropriate Classroom Behavior
- Active Course Participation
- Satisfactory Completion of Assignments
- Progress Toward Academic Goals (as outlined in the [Student Learning Contract](#))

Individual student expectations will be clearly defined for each area of the [Student Learning Contracts](#). Student learning contracts will be submitted directly to the professor at the beginning of the semester by a member of the PACE team (msheppar@sju.edu). An accommodations email will also be sent from the Office of Student Disability Services (SDS); this will reference the student learning contract as well as any other accommodations that the student will be receiving from that office.

[Student Learning Contracts](#) and [Academic Progress Rubrics](#) are the primary tools for determining whether students participating in the PACE program have successfully completed your course.

*In some cases, students may complete courses for credit; in those cases, they will not have a modified syllabus/assignments and would only have appropriate accommodations.

Grading

Students who are taking courses on an audit basis will neither take quizzes or tests, nor receive traditional grades for assignments. However, since students benefit from feedback regarding their strengths and areas for improvement, a request will be made at the midterm and during finals week for the [Academic Progress Rubric](#) to be completed. Students receive an exact copy of your comments. We hope that this is a place to provide encouragement and share any concerns regarding the student's performance in the course.

Students value your feedback. Furthermore, your feedback becomes even more critical when a student is not successfully engaging in the course at midterm. Comments on course participation and engagement allow PACE staff to identify appropriate supports needed for improvement.

Peer Academic Coaches

The PACE program utilizes a research-based peer support model for student participation in inclusive courses. We actively recruit a peer academic coach, who is a degree-seeking student enrolled in your course, for each student in the PACE program. The peer academic coach serves as the student's primary point of contact for the course. The PACE Program Coordinator will send an email prior to the start of the semester with additional information to recruit and hire paid peer coaches.

There are many advantages to both the student in the PACE program and the degree-seeking student in this peer arrangement. The selection of a peer coach gives the student participating in the PACE program a primary "go-to" person for the course, allows them to build connections with peers, and offers needed assistance in a less stigmatizing manner. In addition, acting as a peer coach allows the degree-seeking student to develop problem-solving skills and grow academically and socially. PACE staff welcome suggestions for modifications to our peer coaching model to best fit your course. Please contact the PACE Program Coordinator with any questions or concerns. For more information on peer supports, please visit:

<https://www.erikwcarter.com/peermediated-supports>

Canvas Request

If possible, it is helpful to add the PACE Program Coordinator and PACE Program Director, Rosemary Theveny (rtheveny@sju.edu) and Kaitlyn Martin (kmartin@sju.edu), to your CANVAS course as students. Adding the PACE staff to CANVAS allows them to better assist the students participating in the PACE program in understanding and completing their coursework.

Support for Faculty and Staff

PACE staff are available to provide support and assistance as needed. We will be reaching out to faculty regularly to check in. However, please feel free to contact one of us with suggestions, questions, or concerns. Moreover, members of the PACE Team at Saint Joseph's University provide additional learning opportunities to faculty and staff throughout the academic year. One opportunity organized through the Office of Teaching and Learning is the Faculty Learning Community focused on Universal Design for Learning (UDL) in the college classroom. Contact Mollie Sheppard msheppar@sju.edu if you are interested in learning more about the learning community.

FAQS

Who is a typical student who will be participating in the PACE program?

Students participating in the PACE program are Saint Joseph's University students between the ages of 17-25 who have an intellectual disability*. Students entering the PACE program have academic, employment, and independent living goals like their degree-seeking peers.

*Intellectual disability involves problems with general mental abilities that affect functioning in two areas:

- **intellectual functioning** (such as learning, problem solving, critical thinking)
- **adaptive functioning** (activities of daily life such as communication, organization, money management)

What does meaningful participation mean?

The PACE expects students to be actively engaged in their college courses. Although participation may look different for each student, all students are expected to attend their college courses regularly, be on time and prepared for class, and contribute to the classroom setting.

How do I know the specific expectations of the student in my classroom?

Each student will have a [Student Learning Contract](#) individually tailored to their strengths and an [Academic Progress Rubric](#) to assess their meeting of course objectives. The Academic Progress Rubric outlines classroom expectations in the following areas: Satisfactory Attendance, Appropriate Classroom Behavior, Active Course Participation, Satisfactory Completion of Assignments, and Progress Toward Academic Goals (as outlined in the Student Learning Contract). The Student Learning Contract identifies specific expectations in terms of the content of assignments. Students will share their Learning Contracts along with their accommodation letter at the beginning of the semester. The Student Learning Contract and Academic Progress Rubric are the primary tools for determining if the student has successfully completed the course.

What assignments will a student complete?

Assignment expectations are determined for each student individually. Some students complete modified course work, with modifications recommended by the PACE Team, while others complete traditional coursework as assigned. Assignment expectations are outlined in the Learning Contract.

If a student is taking a course on an audit basis, they will not take exams; instead, they may complete a cumulative Google Slide project that recaps the primary themes learned from the course and includes a personal reflection on learning.

How should students participating in the PACE program be graded?

Students who enroll in courses on an audit basis will be graded at the midterm and end-of-term using the [Academic Progress Rubric](#). Grading on assignments throughout the semester is conducted at the discretion of the professor. If a student is taking a course for-credit, rather than on an audit basis, the standard course grading measures would apply.

What classroom modifications and supports will be helpful to a student participating in the PACE program?

It is never expected that a professor modifies their course for a student. However, one support that the PACE team practices and recommends is having students meet with professors (during office hours) prior to the course to review their learning contract.

What are other ways to support the PACE program and students?

An additional way to support the success of the student in the classroom is by extending access to CANVAS course materials to the PACE instructional staff. Another way to support the program is by sharing your experience working with the PACE program with other professionals within Saint Joseph's University and the greater community! Sharing your story helps to spread awareness of the program on campus, in addition to spotlighting the need for and success of inclusive programs in higher education.

What additional supports are available?

PACE staff are always willing to provide one-on-one support when needed. In addition, PACE provides a Teaching and Learning Community opportunity in Universal Design for Learning (UDL) that is open to all faculty and staff. To learn more, contact Mollie Sheppard msheppar@sju.edu.